Usability Evaluation Report - Envisioning Climate Futures

Prepared by: Akshata Kulkarni

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1. Overview

This report presents findings and recommendations for the Envisioning Climate Futures website. The evaluation is holistic, focusing on technical and design/messaging improvements of the website, along with conducting a user experience observation.

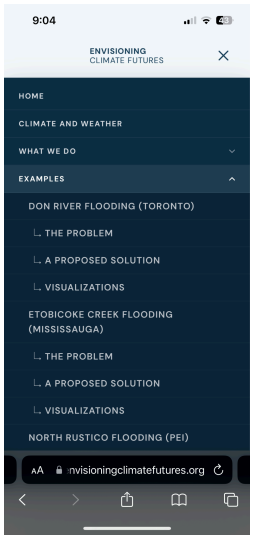
2. Findings and Recommendations

2.1 Technical

On mobile (iOS), the hero video on the landing page plays in full screen once user starts the video playback, which is a notably different experience from desktop where the video continues playing as the user scrolls through the page. This difference in experience allows desktop users to read through other text on the page while listening in to the video. My recommendation is to embed the video on mobile, allowing it to play as the user scrolls through the page.

Images (specifically pictures attached in the "Examples" section, as they may prompt further analysis from the user), should be expandable on mobile devices. This avoids the user having to zoom in on the whole site as a whole as it can be a disorienting experience. A simple expand icon beside each image would improve this experience.

Mobile devices in both portrait and landscape orientation render subheading in a noticeably larger font than the headings itself.



Menu on mobile device

Menu on desktop device

2.2 Design/Messaging

#	Issue	Severity	Platform	Recommendation
1	Navigation labels can be unclear at times	Medium	All	Rename to shorter, more intuitive labels
2	Homepage lacks demonstration of existing work	Low	All	Feature existing models on home page to increase credibility
3	University logos are not clickable despite appearing interactive	Medium	Desktop/ Laptop	Link logos to websites
4	Partner and Sponsors page is text-only	Low	All	Add logos

Issue 1 - Navigation labels can be unclear at times

The "What We Do" dropdown currently contains a subcategory titled "Our Methodology", which itself has the subtopics Vision, Approach, and Goals. Since the words "methodology" and "approach" are very similar (often used as synonyms of one another), these labels can feel redundant. I find that the "Our Methodology" section captures the ethos of the project. My recommendation is to change "Our Methodology" to "Why We Do It", as it creates a narrative flow after the parent step of 'What We Do'.

Additionally, the labels "Modelling and Visualizing Floods" and "Modelling and Visualizing Wildfires" is quite long, and unnecessarily takes the user additional time to read two labels that differ only by a word. Instead, these could benefit from being renamed to "Flood Modelling" and "Wildfire Modelling", since modelling can be interpreted in both a technical way (modelling spread/behaviour of these natural disasters) and a visual way (ensuring model has a strong user impact).

Finally, renaming the "Examples" menu item to "Our Work" would help it fit in with the other menu items, as existing labels like "Who We Are" and "What We Do" follow a collective, first-person tone.

Issue 2 - Homepage lacks demonstration of existing work

As this website represents a relatively new research initiative, first-time visitors may look for signs of credibility and track record. As such, we may benefit from displaying work that we have already done on the main page as a way to draw users in. Seeing previous work on Little Etobicoke Creek and Don River models can help push the idea that we are a new yet established research initiative with experience in this domain. This is similar to how companies will highlight their best products on their homepage or display testimonials to help the user feel trust.

Issue 3 - University logos are not clickable despite appearing interactive

The logos at the footer of the website (UofT, OCAD, UPEI, and Vancouver Island University) increase in size and opacity when hovered over. This makes the logos seem as if they can be interacted with. I recommend these become clickable logos routing to the universities' respective websites to match existing behaviour and add useful context for visitors of the site.

Logos at rest state; no interaction

OCAD Logo appearance when hovered over

Issue 4 - Partner and Sponsors page is text-only

The Partners and Sponsors page lists affiliates as text. Logos are commonly recognized by users and are more visually engaging as opposed to typeface text. Adding logos accompanied by HTML labels that provide a text description of the institutions/affiliates can help the page be more eye-catching, while maintaining accessibility.

2.3 User Experience Observations

The participant is a tech-savvy adult who is unfamiliar with this research project. The session focused on looking for a solid understanding of the initiative from a first-time user.

Overall, the user found the content informative and detailed. The "Examples" section was the highlight of their experience as it presented information as a narrative, walking them through the content with each step. The user also really liked that you can navigate to "The Problem", "A Proposed Solution", and "Visualizations" from both the top and bottom of the page.

Two issues were raised regarding the video widget on the home page. A duplicate expand button was spotted in the bottom right corner, as seen in this image:

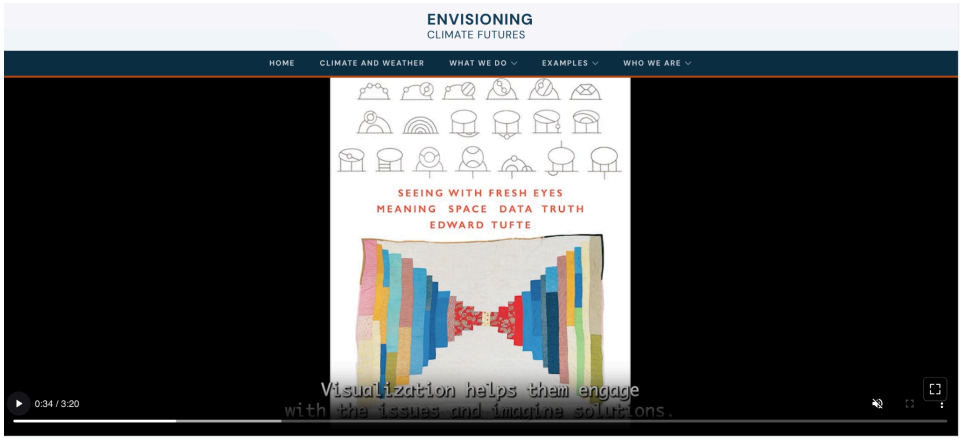
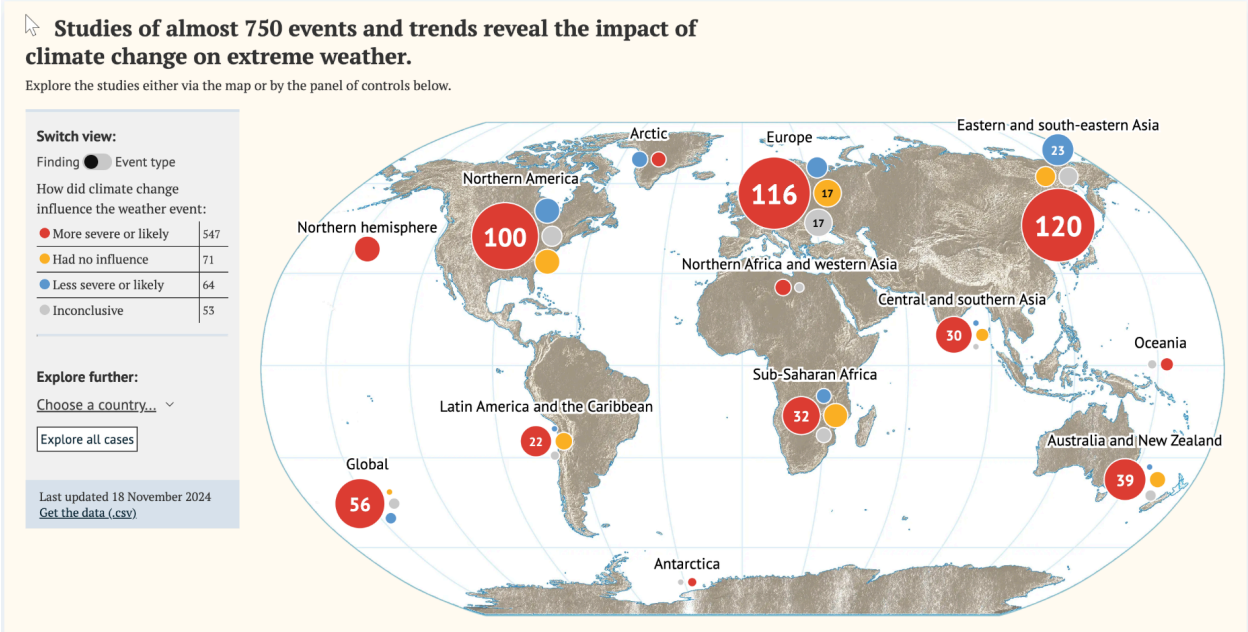


Image showcasing repeated full-screen icons in the bottom-right of video widget

Second, the user hoped to pause/play the video by clicking anywhere on the video instead of having to press the small control button in the bottom-left corner.

When exploring the "Climate and Weather" tab, the user was attempting to interact with the following image:



Impact of climate change on extreme weather events

This is due to the buttons and interactive view this image has, as it prompts the user to Choose a country or toggle views. This caused the user confusion after finding out this was a static visualization.

3. Conclusion

While this report highlights areas for improvement, it's worth noting that the website does an amazing job on design and navigation. Standout aspects include the "Team" page, as it is responsive and well-organized. The "Examples" page was also a highlight, as it does a great job at conveying the magnitude of work that has been done and is crucial for increasing the research initiatives credibility.